those utilizing more neutral or technocratic language. These tests draw on evidence and data from Carnegie, Clark, and Fan (2024).

7.4.1 Twitter-Based Tests of Populist-Style Rhetoric and Engagement

Social media platforms like Twitter have become central to how IOs engage with the public, bypassing government intermediaries and traditional media gatekeepers. We focus on whether IOs use populist-style themes in their tweets and if such messaging resonates more with audiences than other types of tweets.

Our analysis centers on the IMF and World Bank—two prominent IFIs with active social media accounts and significant global influence. As discussed in earlier chapters, these institutions face frequent populist criticism as a result of their elite staffing and imposition of state sovereignty constraints, making them ideal cases for testing our theory. Their large digital footprints also provide a robust dataset for analysis.

We collected tweets from the IMF, World Bank, and their senior officials from 2012 to 2022 using the Twitter API for Academic Research. This dataset spans 89,426 tweets, excluding retweets, comprising 47,225 from the World Bank and 20,675 from the IMF. It also includes 17 senior IO officials' accounts, such as IMF managing directors and World Bank presidents. We selected 2012 as the starting point because this marks a period when IOs began to actively expand their Twitter presence. Both the IMF and World Bank have more than 2 million followers, and their tweets generate significant public interaction. For example, IMF tweets average 58 likes and 27 retweets, while World Bank tweets receive 75 likes and 35 retweets on average. The IMF issues approximately 1,880 tweets annually (157 per month), while the World Bank sends roughly 4,293 tweets per year (357 per month). Senior officials, such as Kristalina Georgieva and Ajay Banga, also actively tweet, with notable engagement levels.

We used supervised machine learning to identify tweets that employ populist-style rhetoric. A training dataset of 7,000 hand-coded tweets served as the foundation for this analysis, with a coding scheme adapted from Ernst et al. (2017). Tweets were classified as "populist-style" if they reflected any of three key characteristics: anti-elitism, where IOs are positioned as